





A UNICORN'S PATH
(Clockwise from left) Vijay Shekhar Sharma at the BSE after IPO listing of Paytm in 2021; with PM Narendra Modi; with Alibaba founder Jack Ma; with wife Mridula and son Vivaan; as a college student in Delhi

teachers." Favourite lyrics: "*I want to run/ I want to hide/ I want to tear the walls that hold me inside*", from U2's 'Where the Streets Have No Name'

STRUGGLE FOR SUCCESS

↘ Started programming/ coding around 1995-96; wrote programmes for firms, including the Delhi-Bombay schedule for Jet Airways. "It got me Rs 1,000...we celebrated with pizza that night"

↘ Quit his first job after six months and started XS Corps! with three friends. In 1999, sold it to a US firm for $1 million. He was just 20

↘ Started One97 Communications in 2000, being pushed into mobile astrology services for survival. Both his partners quit after 9/11. "From being one-third owner, I became 100 per cent owner"

↘ Entered music/ cricket scores space with Bharti Airtel, but hit a low point after running out of cash. Reduced to avoiding a landlord looking for rent and having just tea for dinner. Bailed out by entrepreneur Piyush Agrawal with Rs 8 lakh. "Business started to pick up. I have never looked back since...."

DREAMING BIG

↘ With the wide use of smartphones, Sharma began offering services that enabled people to pay through phones. Enter Paytm in 2010

↘ Heard Jack Ma speak at a 2011 conference. "I was blown by what Taobao, Alipay and Alibaba had done." Ma remains an inspiration, along with Steve Jobs. Paytm hit 100 million users in 2015

↘ In 2019, Paytm extended contract for four years (till March 2023) as title sponsor for international/ domestic cricket matches with BCCI. The winning bid: Rs 3.8 crore per match. But, by July 2022, it asks BCCI to reassign the 'home title' sponsorship to Mastercard

THE CHINESE CATCH

↘ Caught in a controversy when Chinese behemoth Alibaba Group made huge investments in Paytm–becoming its biggest shareholder with a 34.7 per cent stake–before its 2021 IPO. To comply with regulation, Alibaba Group firm Antfin sold shares to lower its stake below 25 per cent, more shares divested later

↘ In January, RBI imposed business restrictions on Paytm Payments Bank effective March 15. "Many times, your teammate and adviser may not be getting it correct," Sharma said in reaction on March 5. But he is not giving up: "I'd like to make Paytm an Asia leader"

– From media reports